

REAL ESTATE AGENT LEAD PLAYBOOK | ENGLISH EDITION

The Pipeline Playbook for Estate Agents

Why listing instructions are slipping — and what established agencies do differently now.

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A system, not another marketing folder.

This document reveals pipeline gaps and helps prioritize the next operating steps with more clarity.

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Note: This playbook is a strategic working guide and not a guarantee of specific outcomes.

1. What most agencies don't want to see right now

Vendor instructions are getting harder and more expensive to win in 2026. Sole agency listings are under pressure from online challengers, and from buyer-led platforms that talk to homeowners long before the first valuation request. Anyone still expecting the next instruction “through a solicitor referral” has been ignoring the wrong data points for three years.

Younger competitors aren't winning because they have better agents. They're winning because they reach the homeowner 6 to 9 months before the sale decision. While you're waiting on the valuation request to land in the inbox, the relationship has already been built somewhere else.

Portal enquiries from buyers are getting less qualified in 2026, not more. Three out of ten enquiries on rightmove, zoopla, daft.ie or myhome.ie today are not serious buyers — they're market watchers, competitor scouts, or holiday-let dreamers. If you don't filter, you burn negotiator hours.

Referrals are drying up. Not because service quality is dropping, but because the generation that triggers referrals is shrinking. That's a demographic truth, not a service truth. You can become better than you've ever been and still get fewer instructions.

Bottom line: The gap between “we're a good agency” and “we win enough instructions” is structurally widening in 2026. That gap is exactly what we specialise in.

2. The pipeline leaks we see most often

Four patterns show up in almost every agency audit we run. They rarely sit at the negotiator's desk. They sit before, beside, or after it. And they cost instructions — quietly, continuously, invisibly.

Leak No. 1 — The valuation request that was never properly followed up

A homeowner requests an online valuation. They get an automated PDF estimate by email. Nobody calls. Three weeks later they instruct a different agency — because that agency rang them the next day with three good questions instead of one estimate. The instruction is gone before you knew there was one.

We see this in 7 of 10 agency audits. Valuation request leads get treated like newsletter sign-ups. Yet the homeowner is at peak intent the moment they submit that form. What happens between submit and human first contact decides the instruction.

Diagnostic hint: If your valuation requests don't get a human call in the first 4 hours, you're losing 40 to 60 % of available instructions at this point alone.

In the audit we test it against your live source — and against what happens in the CRM afterwards.

Leak No. 2 — The invisible tracking death

You spend on local online advertising — Google, Meta, possibly rightmove or daft featured listings. You see contact requests, valuations, maybe instructions. What you don't see: which source genuinely brings instructions, and which just brings expensive clickers. Broken pixel implementations, cookie banner logic, missing server-side tracking — at most agencies it has been frozen at 2019 standards.

In an agency audit last quarter we saw, in 15 minutes, that 38 % of paid enquiries were attributed to the wrong source in the report. Consequence: the team had cut the budget on the best-performing channel because it “wasn't working” on paper.

Diagnostic hint: If your marketing report doesn't show “instructions per source after 90 days”, you're flying blind.

In the audit we test it against your data — and what we find usually isn't what your dashboard says.

Leak No. 3 — The handover that suffocates in the inbox

A vendor enquiry lands at 21:14 on a Sunday. It goes into the general enquiry inbox. Monday 10:30 a.m., someone calls back. 37 hours later. The vendor has, in the meantime, contacted two other agencies. One of them replied at 21:42 on Sunday — automated, with a first qualifying question and a slot link.

What sits inside the CRM of an agency currently winning isn't "more mandatory fields". It's a handover that gives the negotiator, in 30 seconds, the reason for selling, the timeline pressure, the expected value, and whether the vendor has already spoken to other agencies.

Diagnostic hint: If your negotiators "go through the inbox" before every first call, you lose 15 to 25 % of response time — and instructions with it.

What the right vendor handover looks like for your business depends on patch and instruction mix. We show it in the audit.

Leak No. 4 — The 21 days when the vendor goes to a competitor

60 % of all vendors don't instruct an agency at the first appointment. They get comparable valuations, they read, they speak to their solicitor or accountant. What happens between the first meeting and the decision decides the deal. Most agencies do the same thing: nothing. Or one "did you want to chat again briefly" call after ten days.

A systematic vendor follow-up logic in the first 21 days doesn't cost a single extra negotiator appointment. It changes the instruction rate — at the agencies we've worked with, by a double-digit margin.

Diagnostic hint: Look at your last 30 lost vendor first-meetings. How many of them saw a single meaningful touchpoint from you in those 21 days? If the answer is below 50 %, you have a systemic issue.

In the audit we show you where the biggest lever sits — and in what order it pays off.

Bottom line: Spotting these four leaks is the easy part. Closing them in the right order is the work. And that's where it gets interesting.

3. The 5-minute self-check

Seven questions. Score each from 1 (not at all true) to 5 (fully implemented and lived). Be honest. The result is only for you.

#	Question	1-5
1	We know, week by week, how many valuation requests come in — broken down by source.	
2	Our conversion tracking has been audited externally, not just “set up” internally.	
3	Before every vendor first appointment, the reason for selling is clarified through at least four qualification questions.	
4	Inbound vendor enquiries get a first qualified response within 60 minutes — including outside office hours.	
5	We have an automated email sequence that keeps vendors warm for 21+ days without anyone writing it manually.	
6	We know how many of our vendor first-meetings go cold without an instruction after 21 days — and why.	
7	Negotiators and marketing review top leads weekly — not just monthly numbers.	

Scoring

7–14 points — You’re relying on luck and on the residual volume of your referrals. If you’re being honest, you already knew that. The question is what you’re going to do about it.

15–25 points — You have building blocks, but no system. This is where most instructions get lost — not at the bottom, but halfway competent with invisible gaps.

26–35 points — You’re ahead of most competitors. The only question is how scalable your system is — and whether it can handle a second patch or a second language.

4. Why most fixes don't actually work

When an agency notices that the instruction pipeline isn't holding, most reach for one of three levers. None of the three solve the actual problem — and one of them makes it worse.

“Spend more on advertising”

Doesn't work when the pipeline leak sits behind the ads. More enquiries through the same gaps means more wasted budget — and more disappointed vendors who reached out and never heard back.

“New website / new funnel”

Doesn't work when the lead handover and follow-up logic don't follow. A polished site sitting on top of weak qualification, weak handover and weak follow-up is a façade. It improves the form. It does not improve the instruction rate.

“Hire another negotiator”

Doesn't work when lead quality is structurally poor. You burn salary on unqualified enquiries — and lose your best people to the frustration of running cold appointments.

A PropTech sales system is not an advertising add-on, not a website refresh, not a hiring substitute. It is the sales infrastructure inside which advertising, websites and people actually start to work. Order matters in 2026: infrastructure first, then advertising, then people.

5. What a working system looks like

We deliberately describe the end picture only in outline here. What it looks like in your business depends on patch, instruction mix and vendor profile. The components, however, are the same in every setup.

1. A vendor-specific funnel that qualifies valuation requests before they reach a negotiator — bilingual where your vendor mix touches DACH or international owners.
2. A CRM handover that gives the negotiator, in 30 seconds, the reason for sale, the timeline pressure, the expected value, and the competitive context.
3. An automated vendor follow-up sequence that stays useful through the first 21 days — without anyone writing it manually.
4. A weekly pipeline report: instructions per source, per stage, per negotiator.

We build exactly that. In 10 to 15 working days from asset sign-off. Bilingual EN/DE, native in both. No instruction promises, with a clearly defined system delivery guarantee. What it means for your specific agency is the audit conversation.

6. The next step: 30 minutes that can change everything

What it is

A 30-minute diagnostic call on Microsoft Teams, with Franz Romih directly.

What you get

- Three concrete pipeline leaks in your current setup, named against examples from your own enquiries.
- An honest fit assessment — even if the answer is that we're not the right partner.
- Clarity on the right next step — with us or without us.

What it is not

- Not a sales call.
- Not a generic pitch.
- Not a written free report.

Who should book it

- Agency directors or principals with concrete instruction or growth pressure in the next 4 to 8 weeks.
- Decision-makers with budget and hiring authority.
- Anyone who genuinely wants their team's pipeline status diagnosed against their actual numbers.

Who should not book it

- "Just looking" calls.
- Solo agents without team structure or marketing budget.
- Anyone hunting for a guaranteed instruction or lead count.

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Bottom line: If after these 9 pages you're thinking: "Makes sense, but I need clarity for my team and my patch" — that's exactly why the Pipeline Audit exists. 30 minutes. Honest. Concrete. No charge.

THE NEXT STEP

Have your current lead system reviewed.

If you want to see which gaps in your current setup are costing real pipeline, book a Pipeline Audit. We review funnel logic, lead qualification, CRM handover and reporting against your actual system.

Book Pipeline Audit